

Baptism

This lesson is the third in the series entitled “The Beginner’s Bible Study.” Other lessons in this series can be obtained through the Lehigh Valley Baptist Church.

The lessons are designed to be first studied, then the questions in the back answered, and then reviewed with the help of an older Christian.

***“As ye have therefore received Christ Jesus
the Lord, so walk ye in Him.”***

Colossians 2:6

*Lehigh Valley Baptist Church
4702 Colebrook Avenue
Emmaus, PA 18049*

*(610) 965-4700
www.lvbaptist.org*

OBEDIENCE TO THE WORD OF GOD

We will start off this study on baptism with the word OBEDIENCE because the first step of obedience after salvation is baptism. Obedience really is the key. We read in John 8:31, *“Then said Jesus to those Jews which believed on him, If ye continue in my word, then are ye my disciples indeed.”*

Christians desire to obey God.

The Bible tells us that once we are saved—if we really are saved—we will want to continue in the word of God. It will be a natural by-product of our life.

Now that doesn't mean that we'll always be perfect, or that we'll never sin. But it does mean that the overall principle of our life is going to be one of desiring to live for the Lord Jesus Christ and be obedient to Him.

In John 14:15-24, Jesus says, *“If ye love me, keep my commandments. He that hath my commandments, and keepeth them, he it is that loveth me: and he that loveth me shall be loved of my Father, and I will love him, and will manifest myself to him...If a man love me, he will keep my words; and my Father will love him, and we will come unto him, and make our abode with him...He that loveth me not keepeth not my sayings: and the word which ye hear is not mine, but the Father's which sent me.”*

The mark of a saved child of God is obedience. We want to obey the Lord. I remember when I got saved the first thing that I wanted to do was obey the Lord. Sadly, there wasn't anyone around to show

me what to do. No one seemed to take enough of an interest after I got saved to say, “Okay, this is the path you need to begin to walk.” No one opened up the Bible to say, “Doug, here is what you need.” Nobody took me aside with a one-week Bible study—let alone an eight-week Bible study—to help me get my feet on the ground spiritually. I floundered for quite some time. But I wanted to obey the Lord—that was the desire of my heart.

One mark of a Christian is a desire to obey God. As they find out what God says, they want to do it. If they see something in the Bible and have truly been born again, they have such a heart of love and joy with having been saved and having a home in Heaven that they are ready to do whatever God says to do. They just want to obey the Lord.

It’s the old, crusty Christians who have been around for a while, and like to “hem and haw” and hedge and hold back on God. But the young Christians are the ones that just want to dive off, and they are ready to go. That is how it ought to be, even in an older Christian’s life.

Christians ought to obey God rather than men.

We need to recognize that once we have been saved and have a desire to serve the Lord, everyone is not going to be excited about the decision we have made. When you got saved everybody didn’t jump up and down and clap their hands like you thought they would. They didn’t pat you on the back and say, “That’s great!”

And probably the saddest thing is that even when you talked to some saved people and told them that you had been born again, they

didn't smile, look happy or even look like they believed it. I remember when I first told a Christian that I had gotten saved, he looked at me and cocked his head to one side as if to say, "I'll believe it when I see it." That put a damper on me a little bit, and then I decided, "Well, I don't care what he thinks, God said He saved me so that's good enough!" and I just went right on. I believe you need to recognize there are going to be times when people are not going to like the fact that you are following Jesus Christ.

I like what Peter said in Acts 5:29 when he was told to quit preaching in the name of Jesus Christ. Peter and the other apostles answered, "*We ought to obey God rather than men.*"

We need to realize that as Christians, we ought to obey God rather than men. When we can find it in the Bible, or we find out what God desires for our life, we ought to do it. It doesn't matter what men may think, and it doesn't matter what men may say. It does matter what God says. Let's be obedient to the Lord Jesus Christ. Let's do what He has to say.

SIX QUESTIONS FOR CHRISTIANS

What is the first command after salvation?

Once a person has been saved, what is the first command? Come to church? No. Change your clothes and get a haircut? No. Give your money? No. Buy a Bible and read your Bible a lot? No. All those things are good, but what is the first command?

Matthew 28:19-20 says, "*Go ye therefore, and teach all nations, baptizing them in the name of the Father, and of the Son and of the*

Holy Ghost: teaching them to observe all things whatsoever I have commanded you: and, lo, I am with you always, even unto the end of the world. Amen.”

God’s command here is very plain and very clear. The order is: (1) salvation (2) baptism and (3) teaching them all things. You don’t have any business worrying about learning things or changing things or rearranging things until first you have been born again. It won’t do you any good to try to rearrange your life and make it pleasing to God or “pretty it up” and think that somehow God is going to accept you like that. He won’t do it. You must be saved—you must be born again.

But after being saved the next step for a child of God is baptism. After you have been baptized, then it is time for you to begin to grow as a child of God. Salvation, baptism, and then training, is God’s order. He has never set down any other kind of an order.

Let me show you how this happens in the Bible over and over again. In Acts 2:38, Peter had been preaching on the day of Pentecost. Several men cried out, “*Men and brethren, what shall we do?*” They are under conviction. They want to get saved.

Peter replies to them, “*Repent, and be baptized, every one of you in the name of Jesus Christ for the remission of sins, and ye shall receive the gift of the Holy Ghost. For the promise is unto you, and to your children, and to all that are afar off, even as many as the Lord our God shall call. And with many other words did he testify and exhort, saying, Save yourselves from this untoward generation. Then they that gladly received his word were baptized: and the same day there were added unto them about three thousand souls.*”

Notice the order. Peter says, number one you repent. Number two, you get baptized. Here he has been laying the emphasis on salvation but he's also saying that once you have been born again you are going to want to follow the Lord in baptism.

What did these people do as soon as they got saved? They got baptized. They didn't even put it off until the next day, they got baptized the same day.

Someone reading may make a mistake and say, "That says that you have to be baptized to be saved." But it can't be read that way. Look carefully at verse 38. He says, "*Repent, and be baptized every one of you in the name of Jesus Christ for the remission of sins.*"

Some people say, "Baptism remits your sins, it takes your sins away." But if you read it carefully, that is not what it is saying. First of all, we know that salvation is only in what Christ has done, not what we have done. So baptism couldn't save us. Secondly, salvation is by the grace of God, not by the works of man. Baptism is the works of man.

To help us better understand what this verse mean, let's use this simple illustration: *The man who gets on the bus and sits down will arrive in New York tomorrow.* Now, let's ask some questions. Do you have to *sit down* on the bus in order to get to New York? The answer is no. You don't have to sit down on a bus to get to New York. You do have to *get* on a bus to go to New York, but you don't have to sit down. You can choose to *swing from the hat racks* just like a monkey all the way to New York, if you wish. You will still get to New York either way—sitting down or swinging from the hat rack.. The key is getting on the bus, not sitting down. But the normal way for most people is to get on the bus, then to sit down.

That is what he is saying in these verses. Just as getting on the bus is the necessary act to get you to New York, *receiving* Jesus Christ is the necessary act for a person to be saved.

Then normally, after receiving Christ, a believer will want to get baptized because it is a command of Christ. That is the normal thing for a Christian today. However, his sins are remitted because of salvation, not because of baptism.

We could use another kind of illustration to make it clearer. Suppose we say, “The man was convicted and sent to jail *for* stealing.” Did they send him to jail so he can steal from everybody there? No, of course not! He is sent to jail *because he has already stolen* something. He goes to jail to pay for what he has done.

The Bible is not saying that the baptism takes away your sins, it is saying that you get baptized because your sins HAVE ALREADY BEEN remitted. They have already been taken away. That is what this passage is talking about.

A man does not go to jail for stealing in order to steal, he goes to jail for stealing because he already has stolen. A man gets baptized for the remission of sins, not in order to have his sins remitted, but because his sins have already been remitted when he trusted Jesus Christ as his Savior. The Bible is saying the normal thing that happens when a man gets saved is that he gets baptized immediately thereafter.

Another verse in Acts 8 is interesting. Here Philip is preaching to the Ethiopian eunuch and in verses 36-38 the eunuch asks, “*What doth hinder me to be baptized? And Philip said, If thou believest with all*

thine heart, thou mayest. And he answered and said, I believe that Jesus Christ is the son of God. And he commanded the chariot to stand still and they went down both into the water.”

Here is a man who has already believed on Jesus Christ. He already believes Jesus is the Christ. He has believed on Him while sitting in the chariot as Philip was talking to him. As soon as he believed that Jesus was the Christ he said, “When can I get baptized?” He got baptized immediately after believing on the Lord Jesus Christ.

What is the first command of Christ after a person has been born again? It is baptism. That is the first marching order that the Lord Jesus Christ gives to you and I.

Who can be baptized?

Another question that is often asked is, “Who can be baptized?” In Acts 2:41 the Bible says, “*Then they that gladly received His word were baptized: and the same day there were added unto them about three thousand souls.*”

Who is baptized here in verse 41? It was those that gladly received the Word. The only people who have the right to be baptized are those who have already received the Word, or believed the Word. In Acts 8 the question was asked, “*What doth hinder me to be baptized? And Philip said, if thou believest with all thine heart, thou mayest. And he answered and said, I believe that Jesus Christ is the Son of God.*”

Baptism is not baptism unless a person has been saved first. There must be a salvation experience. Anything else is not baptism unless that person has been born again FIRST.

Some people say, “I think that maybe you get baptized and you get saved at the same time.” Oh, no! These verses make it very, very clear you receive the Word first and then you get baptized. You first believe on the Lord Jesus Christ and then you get baptized. They are distinct events, and although they may happen the very same day, they are still distinct.

I get a little shaky and a little bothered when I ask somebody, “Have you been saved?” and they start to tell me about their baptism, their church membership, or how good they are. I immediately begin to bring up question marks in my mind. “Does this person even know what salvation is all about?” Salvation is believing on the Lord Jesus Christ. Baptism takes place after that. No one has a right to be baptized until they have been born again.

Here is an interesting thought. In Acts 8:36-37, we read, “*The eunuch said, See, here is water; what doth hinder me to be baptized? And Philip said, If thou believeth with all thine heart, thou mayest. And he answered and said, I believe that Jesus Christ is the Son of God.*”

This man not only believed that he'd been saved, but he had assurance of his salvation. He was sure he was saved. There wasn't any question about it in his heart. When a person gets saved, they will have assurance from God that they have been born again.

How should a person be baptized?

Then, a third question often asked is, “How should a person be baptized?” There are methods that different denominations use. One says you ought to be sprinkled a little bit and someone ought to flip a little water on your head.

Another denomination says you ought to have water poured on your head. Yet another denomination may say you ought to be baptized by being put under the water—immersed or dipped under the water. So, we have a controversy. What is the Bible way of baptism? How should you be baptized?

*They were **IN** the water.*

Let’s allow the Bible to speak for itself. In Matthew 3:6 we read, “*And were baptized of him, **in** Jordan, confessing their sins.*” Look at what verse 16 says, “*And Jesus, when he was baptized, went up straightway **out of the water**: And lo, the heavens were opened unto him, and he saw the Spirit of God descending like a dove, and lighting upon him.*”

Do you need to be **in** the Jordan River if you are going to be sprinkled? Do you need to be **in** the Jordan River if somebody is going to pour some water on your head? Or do you need to be **in** the Jordan River if you are going to be put **under the water**? Under the water is the correct answer.

*Jesus came **UP** out of the water.*

In verse 16 it says Jesus went up straightway out of the water. How do you come up **out of the water** if you have been sprinkled? You don’t come up out of the water, the water comes down on top of you. How do you come up out of the water if you are poured on? You

can't. The water comes, once again, down on you in a little bit bigger stream than sprinkling.

But in baptism, in immersion, you are put under the water, you come up **out of the water** after you have gone down into the water. You have been dipped, put under and brought back up again. That is what happened to the Lord Jesus Christ.

*They needed **MUCH** water.*

In John 3:23 it says, “*And John also was baptizing in Aenon near to Salim, because there was **much** water there: and they came and were baptized.*”

Now, why do you need much water? You don't need much water to sprinkle people, a little bit will do. I remember when the priest used to come by. He'd stick that little thing (it's a little ball with horns on it) in the water and just fling that water everywhere. It didn't take much water at all for him to be able to do that. Pouring takes a little bit more water, but not a whole lot. A glass will do for quite a few little kids.

But for baptism, or immersion, you need **much** water. The Bible says here, John went to Aenon near to Salim because there was **much** water there. That's why he baptized at that place.

*They went **DOWN INTO** the water.*

In Acts 8:36 the Bible says, “*And as they went on their way, they came unto a certain water: and the eunuch said, See, here is water; what doth hinder me to be baptized? And Philip said, If thou believest with all thine heart, thou mayest. And he answered and*

*said, I believe that Jesus Christ is the Son of God. And he commanded the chariot to stand still: and they went **down both into the water**, both Philip and the eunuch; and he baptized him.”*

Now, why would he need to go down into the water? Why would they wade out into the water? And again, the only reason is because it is immersion, not pouring or sprinkling, that the Bible talks about.

*It was a **PICTURE** of burial and resurrection.*

There is another passage in Romans which is very clear. In Romans 6:3, the Bible says, “*Know ye not, that so many of us as were baptized into Jesus Christ were baptized into his death? Therefore we are **buried** with him by baptism into death: that like as Christ was **raised up** from the dead by the glory of the Father, even so we also should walk in newness of life. For if we have been **planted** together in the likeness of his death, we shall be also in the likeness of his **resurrection**: Knowing this, that our old man is crucified with him, that the body of sin might be destroyed, that henceforth we should not serve sin.*”

Here the Bible says baptism is being **buried** and **raised**. Baptism is being **planted** and **resurrected**. In sprinkling there is no picture or symbolism of being buried and risen again. There is no symbolism of being planted and resurrected when you get sprinkled.

There is no symbolism of being planted or of being buried when you have water poured on top of your head. But when you go down into the waters—when you are laid back in the waters and then brought back up—that is a picture of burial and resurrection.

We will look at one last verse to answer this question. In Colossians 2:12 it says, “**Buried** with him in baptism, wherein also ye are risen with him through the faith of the operation of God, who hath raised him from the dead.”

The Bible answer for the question of how a person should be baptized is very clear. It is burial and resurrection. It is going down into the water and coming back up. It takes much water, and you must have water in order to be baptized, a good deal of it. It is immersion, going down into the water and coming back up.

*They were immersed only **ONCE**.*

If you study the Bible you will find a person is immersed under the water only one time and then brought back up. Not three times under, not three times forward or three times backwards or six times or twenty times or however many other times that some other denomination is going to come up with.

But the Word of God teaches that Jesus went down one time into the water and came back up. The Ethiopian eunuch went one time down into the water and back up. John’s converts went one time down into the water and back up.

Never in the Bible were they ever immersed any more than one time. There are some denominations that teach falsely that a person should be immersed three times. That is a fallacy and it is not found in the Bible.

Why should a person be baptized?

Why is it so important? I will give you some Bible reasons why, if you have been saved, you ought to be baptized. These are not all the reasons found in the Bible, but some of the more important ones.

We are baptized so we can identify with Christ.

In Romans 6:3 we read, “*Know ye not, that so many of us as were baptized into Jesus Christ were baptized into his death? Therefore we are buried with him by baptism into death: that like as Christ was raised up from the dead by the glory of the Father, even so we also should walk in newness of life. For if we have been planted together in the likeness of his death, we shall be also in the likeness of his resurrection.*”

Why should a person be immersed? Why should they be baptized? A person is baptized in order to identify with the death, burial and resurrection of the Lord Jesus Christ. As you are put under the water it is a picture of the fact that you have died and are buried. Then, as you come back up again, it is a picture that you are resurrected to a new life, and that you want to live for Christ.

But it is especially a testimony that you believe Jesus died and was buried, and three days later, came forth out of the grave alive. He came forth under His own power, not the power of other people dragging Him out of the grave. Jesus Christ rose from the dead. Baptism is an identification with the Lord Jesus Christ. It is a very important identification with Him.

We are baptized to confess Christ before men.

Then, in Matthew 10 is another important reason to be baptized. We have already seen that it is a command from God. Matthew 10:32 says, *“Whosoever therefore shall confess me before men, him will I confess also before my Father which is in heaven.”*

We must also ask the question, “What happens if we don’t confess Him?” Verse 33 says, *“But whosoever shall deny me before men, him will I also deny before my Father which is in heaven.”*

I am not saying that you have to be baptized in order to be saved. But I am saying that there is something very peculiar about a person who knows Jesus Christ and is afraid to tell other people that they have been saved.

There is something wrong with somebody who says, “I have been born again, but I don’t want anybody to know. I want to keep this thing a secret. I want to be a secret disciple.” The Bible indicates that there is something wrong with that man’s salvation. He doesn’t seem to have the kind of salvation that the Bible talks about.

When a person got saved in the Bible, they immediately confessed that they belonged to Jesus Christ, they wanted others to know. Jesus warned men, “If you deny me before men, I’ll deny you before my Father in Heaven.” He’s not saying, “You’re going to lose it,” but He is saying, “I’m questioning whether or not you ever got it! You are not one of mine if you are a secret disciple.”

A Christian ought to be baptized. A person who has been born again ought to be baptized in order to confess Christ to men and to let the world know they have been born again. They ought to let the world know they have believed on the Lord Jesus Christ, to make public what has happened in their life.

We are baptized to become a member of a New Testament church.

For the third reason, in Acts 2:41 the Bible says, “*Then they that gladly received His word were baptized and the same day there were added unto them about three thousand souls.*” When they were baptized, what were they added to? To “them” it says. Let’s read verse 47 and find out who “them” is. “*Praising God and having favor with all the people and the Lord added to the church daily such as should be saved.*”

In I Corinthians 12:13 it says, “*For by one Spirit are we all baptized into one body, whether we be Jews or Gentiles, whether we be bond or free, and have been all made to drink into one Spirit.*”

When a person is baptized, they are put into the local church. They are put into that church’s ministry. They become a part of that church. Why should a person be baptized once they are saved? Because that is the door into the New Testament church where they are to serve the Lord Jesus Christ for the rest of their days.

We are baptized to have a clear conscience before God.

The fourth reason we have in I Peter 3:21. The Bible says, “*The like figure whereunto even baptism doth also now save us, (not the putting away the filth of the flesh, but the answer of a good conscience toward God) by the resurrection of Jesus Christ.*”

Baptism helps to give us a good conscience toward the Lord Jesus Christ. It helps to give us an assurance that we have truly been born again and that we have committed ourselves to the Lord Jesus Christ. There is a commitment in going down into the waters of baptism. There is a commitment that you make when you submit

yourself to baptism for you have submitted yourself to that local church and you have said, “I want to be one with you and I want my name to be written down as one who wants to walk with the Lord Jesus Christ from this day forward.” And so, there is the answer of a clear conscience to God in this matter.

Where should a person be baptized?

Let’s take a look in Matthew 28 to find where we should be baptized. Some people say, “I have a friend down the road, maybe he’ll stick me in his bathtub.” Or, “She has a great big spa, and maybe she’ll stick me under and pull me back up.” And someone else says, “I’ve got some friends who are good Christians over in New York. I’ll just run over there and let them do it.” Where should we be baptized?

In Matthew 28:16 the Bible says, *“Then the eleven disciples went away into Galilee, into a mountain where Jesus had appointed them, and when they saw Him, they worshipped Him, but some doubted. Jesus came and spake unto them, All power is given unto me in heaven and in earth, go ye therefore and teach all nations, baptizing them in the name of the Father and of the Son and of the Holy Ghost.”*

Here the Lord Jesus Christ was talking to His disciples, not as individuals, but as a corporate group. They were a New Testament church that He had already organized. He was giving to the church the ordinance of baptism. In other words, no individual has the right to baptize you. You need to be baptized under the authority of a local New Testament church. You ask, “Is there any other proof in the Bible?” The answer is, “Yes.”

I Corinthians 11:2 makes this very clear. Paul writes and says, “*Now I praise you, brethren, that you remember me in all things and keep the ordinances as I delivered them to you.*”

Now, who is ‘you?’ He is writing here to the church in Corinth as we find in chapter 1. What are the ordinances? There are only two ordinances in the Bible. There is baptism and there is the Lord’s Supper. Those are the only two ordinances given to the local church—not to the individual Christian. The only proper place to be baptized is at a local New Testament church.

From Biblical doctrine we believe that it ought to be a Baptist church, at least in practice. Maybe not in name, but definitely in practice. There are some churches with the name Baptist on the outside that are not Baptist inside. So you don’t just follow a church because it has a name on the door. You should check out what they believe on the inside.

Do they believe and practice the Word of God? If they deny God’s Book, my friend, then they are not a church of the Lord Jesus Christ. If they deny the person of Jesus Christ, the works of Jesus Christ, the death of Jesus Christ, the resurrection of Jesus Christ, the deity of Jesus Christ, or the virgin birth of Jesus Christ, then they are not a church of Jesus Christ! They don’t have any right from God, therefore, to baptize a person.

When should a person be baptized?

We have already asked what the first commandment is that Christ has given. You need to be baptized after you have been saved.

Secondly we asked, “Who can be baptized?” According to Scripture, only saved people can be baptized. A church that baptizes any people other than saved people isn’t a New Testament church.

Third of all we asked, “How should you be baptized?” We have shown you from the Bible that it needs to be immersion under the water, not sprinkling or pouring. A church that allows sprinkling or pouring and authorizes that as baptism is not a church of the Lord Jesus Christ.

Then question number four, “Why should you be baptized?” You are baptized in order to identify with Christ, to confess Christ, to be added to the church and to have a good conscience. And if a church baptizes you in order to save you, then they are not a New Testament church. If they baptize to help you get saved, then they are not a New Testament church. So what we are saying is, the reason why you are being baptized must be right and the church that is doing the baptizing needs to understand the reason why they are baptizing you.

Then number five was, “Where should you be baptized?” It should be a New Testament church that adheres to Bible doctrine, especially in these areas that we have discussed.

Now, last of all we are asking the question, “When should you be baptized?” We have already asked the question, “Who?” and that is people who have been saved. When then should you be baptized?

How long should you wait? Should you wait for a six-month course? Should you wait for a ten-month course, or a twelve-month course? How about a ten-year course, and then you can finally be baptized and join a church! Let’s read Acts 2 and see when the people got baptized in the Bible.

In Acts 2:41, the Bible says, *“Then they that gladly received his word were baptized: and the same day there were added unto them about three thousand souls.”*

In other words, they didn't wait. They took the first available opportunity to be baptized after they had been saved and they had been born again.

In Acts 16:31, we read the passage of scripture where the Philippian jailer has asked Paul and Silas, "*Sirs, what must I do to be saved? And they said, Believe on the Lord Jesus Christ, and thou shalt be saved, and thy house. And they spake unto him the word of the Lord, and to all that were in his house. And he took them the same hour of the night, and washed their stripes; and was baptized, he and all his, straightway.*"

In other words, the same day in which the Philippian jailer got saved, what did he do? He went out and got baptized—that very night he got baptized.

CONCLUSION

If you have been born again, if you have been saved, if you are a child of God, but you have never yet followed the Lord in baptism, Luke 6:46 asks, "*And why call ye me, Lord, Lord, and do not the things which I say?*"

Could I ask you the same question if you are saved and have never been baptized? Why do you say that you are a child of God when you won't obey God? If you have been saved, Christ expects you to be obedient.

QUESTIONS ON BAPTISM

1. The mark of a child of God when we get saved is _____.
2. According to Acts 5:29 we ought to obey _____ rather than men.
3. Which of the following is the Biblical pattern?

#1	#2	#3
a. Baptism	a. Salvation	a. Salvation
b. Salvation	b. Baptism	b. Teaching
c. Teaching	c. Teaching	c. Baptism
4. Is baptism necessary for salvation?
5. Who may be Scripturally baptized?
6. Why were believers baptized in the Jordan River? To be:
 - a. sprinkled
 - b. poured upon
 - c. put under the water
7. According to Romans 6:3,4 baptism is a picture of being _____ and _____, _____ and _____.

8. During a baptism, how many times should the believer be immersed?
9. Why should a person be immersed?
10. Is a person truly saved if he wants to remain a “secret disciple?”
11. What is the “door” into the New Testament church?
12. Do individuals have the authority, or right, to baptize? Who does?
13. What are the two ordinances given to the local church?
 - 1.
 - 2.
14. Where should a believer be baptized?
15. Should a person be baptized immediately after being saved according to Acts 2:41?
16. What is the most important thing you have learned in this lesson?